

For Josh Software, Open Source is the Foundation of its Business

Despite being unfavourably compared to Java, many high-profile consumer Web firms are using Ruby on Rails to build agile and scalable Web applications. Today, 211,295 websites have been running Ruby on Rails. And this has proved to be a launch pad for several businesses. Josh Software is one such successful business, that originated out of its founders' sheer passion for open source software and Ruby on Rails. **Saurabh Singh from *Open Source For You* spoke to Gautam Rege, co-founder and director, Josh Software**, about how he fell in love with Ruby on Rails, and how the initial infatuation has now blossomed into something far more long term!



Gautam Rege, co-founder and director, Josh Software

Ever wondered how to make money out of something that is available for free? Well, Josh Software's success story is a case study in how open source software can convert a business idea into a money-making enterprise. Josh Software works entirely with Ruby on Rails. This is the only open source software that the company has banked on ever since it was formed in 2007. Gautam Rege, co-founder and director, Josh Software, proudly states, "Today, we have made Josh Software a one-stop shop for everything to do with Ruby on Rails. The company is involved in building Web applications working exclusively with Ruby on Rails." Though the team behind Josh Software doesn't want

to restrict itself to just open source software, it doesn't want to make any compromises by adopting proprietary software either. Says Rege, "As a company, we look at all new and emerging software, especially those in the open source spectrum."

Open source software and the hardships linked to it

So why was open source software like Ruby On Rails selected? Says Rege, "We realised that the need of the hour, when we started, was to have systems going online -- systems that were flexible. Rails emerged as a natural choice when we were researching our options. Rails as a framework lets you quickly build applications that are flexible, scalable and efficient. And then we fell in love with Ruby!" The fact that Ruby as a language is so malleable that it can be adapted into doing what programmers want, and that it is so easy to learn, is what led Josh Software to build its business on this platform.

But the journey was not as smooth and easy as it sounds today. The team has had its share of hardships. Rege remembers, "Although the first couple of years were really tough for us to get work, I am glad that betting on an open source language in an open source Web framework has eventually paid off." The majority of its clients are funded start-ups, and such businesses often want to get things done fast. Rege recalls how important the 'proof of concept' was some years ago. Companies would look for the fastest way to build something and once the concept was proven, one needed to restart from scratch. "Now, Rails comes with a 'proof of concept' mechanism that can be automatically enhanced to become the 'real' thing. Start-ups are more compliant and look for new emerging teams that get things done fast without burning a big hole in the pocket. With open source software, you get so much that is already made that you don't need to restart from scratch. You can easily get a product that gets built to concept, to implementation and to scale, all in one go," he says.